Our impressive form in 2012 continued into the new year, with two emphatic Test victories over a New Zealand touring squad that included a talented left-arm fast bowler named Neil Wagner – the self-same Neil Wagner who arrived at Affies a couple of years after me and who, as a younger boy, had been told to carry my cricket bag around, just as I had once been told to shoulder Jacques Rudolph's cricket bag.

Neil was one of a few South African cricketers who had sensed a lack of opportunity at home, where racial quotas were constantly mooted, and decided to pursue his career in New Zealand. He had taken a massive decision and made it work but it still felt strange: we'd been friends at high school and then teammates at the Titans and, barely a decade later, we were playing against each other in international cricket.

The opening match of the ODI series that followed was lost when we narrowly failed to defend 208 in Paarl, but that was only the start of our problems. We had taken too long to bowl our overs and, according to the ICC Code of Conduct, the consequence of falling six overs short of our target was that (1) the captain – in this case, me – was banned from the next two one-day internationals, and (2) each player was fined 100% of his match fee.

Rules are rules, as they say, but it had been an exceptionally hot and windy day and we had conceded no fewer than 18 extras, which meant we had had to bowl the equivalent of three additional overs. I felt that such mitigating factors should be taken into account but David Boon, the former Australian batsman turned ICC match referee, was adamant that the guidelines should be upheld and the full punishment should be imposed.

This saga frustrated and embarrassed me, and it provided a few of the experts with an opportunity to cast further doubt on my ability as a captain. Oh well, I told myself, control the controllables. I resolved to learn and move on, but it was hard to sit in the stands and watch as we lost in Kimberley before winning in Potchefstroom.

Next up … Pakistan arrived on tour.